PARIS, FRANCE

Musée de l’Orangerie: Masterpieces

Twenty works in which scale, outlines and colour change the way a subject is recognised.



A black ribbon can organise a portrait. At the Orangerie, it can also be compared with a curtain of willow branches spread across a much wider field. Modigliani concentrates attention around a neck and face; Monet offers a pond without the familiar support of a horizon. The scale and the means of orientation both change.

This selection places three *Water Lilies* compositions alongside portraits, landscapes and interiors. The connection is not that all dissolve into abstraction. It is that each asks how much a recognisable subject depends on outlines, proportion, colour or setting. A factory by Rousseau and a tilted landscape by Soutine answer that question very differently.

Artline selected these works from documented museum holdings. The selection is independent of the museum, and individual works may be on loan or off display. Dates and attributions retain the qualifications in the linked records.

Explore this selection in Artline

See the selected works alongside books and events from their period, or compare when the artists lived. The books and events provide context, not evidence of direct influence. Works without confirmed dates remain in this guide.

Artworks in context Who lived when?

artlines.org/guides/musee-orangerie

The selection · 20

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01 / 20

Woman with a Velvet Ribbon

Amedeo Modigliani

1915 · Oil on canvas · Musée de l’Orangerie



A woman with velvet ribbon. WikiArt; Amedeo Modigliani. Proportional resizing and JPEG compression; source frame preserved. · Public domain

The black ribbon makes the long neck impossible to treat as an incidental distortion. It marks a narrow horizontal line across an emphatic vertical, drawing attention to the proportion that holds head and body apart. Dark hair and the pale face repeat this economy of contrast, leaving the portrait concentrated in a few conspicuous decisions.

Object source · Open artwork

02 / 20

Cliffs

Henri Rousseau

c. 1897 · Oil on canvas · Musée de l’Orangerie



Henri Rousseau. Cliffs. WikiArt source label: Public domain. Proportional resize and JPEG compression; no crop. Source: https://www.wikiart.org/en/henri-rousseau/cliffs · Public domain (WikiArt source label)

Vertical ridges make the cliff a different kind of shape from the long strips of sea and shore. Small boats take their positions within that simplified order. The coast remains identifiable, but its clarity depends less on abundant detail than on how firmly each element has been placed in relation to the others.

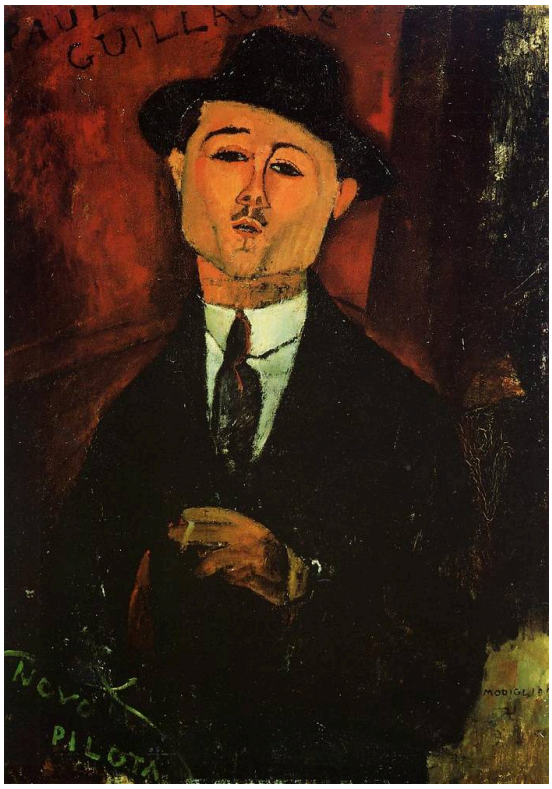
Object source · Open artwork

03 / 20

Paul Guillaume

Amedeo Modigliani

1915 · Oil on cardboard · Musée de l’Orangerie



Amedeo Modigliani. Paul Guillaume. WikiArt source label: Public domain. Proportional resize and JPEG compression; no crop. Source: https://www.wikiart.org/en/amedeo-modigliani/paul-guillaume-1915 · Public domain (WikiArt source label)

The dark suit and hat form a compact silhouette against red. The isolated hand near the chest introduces an action within that otherwise contained shape. Modigliani gives the young dealer a deliberate public presence, making authority a matter of pose and contrast rather than an elaborate interior or collection of possessions.

Object source · Open artwork

04 / 20

Portrait of Émile Lejeune

Chaim Soutine

1925 · Oil on canvas · Musée de l’Orangerie



Chaim Soutine. Portrait of Emile Lejeune. WikiArt source label: Public domain. Proportional resize and JPEG compression; no crop. Source: https://www.wikiart.org/en/chaim-soutine/portrait-of-emile-lejeune-1925 · Public domain (WikiArt source label)

The face's uneven angles continue into a visibly worked background instead of settling into a polished surface. Those irregularities keep the likeness active without making the sitter unrecognisable. Soutine offers a useful counterpart to Modigliani's long, controlled contours: both alter a face, but the alterations organise attention in different ways.

Object source · Open artwork

05 / 20

The Chair Factory at Alfortville

Henri Rousseau

1897 · Oil on canvas · Musée de l’Orangerie



The chair factory at Alfortville. WikiArt; Henri Rousseau. Proportional resizing and JPEG compression; source frame preserved. · Public domain

The low factory holds its edges beneath clouds that swell more broadly above it. Small figures and the branching road give the industrial site a modest human scale. Rousseau allows a place of work to share the formal stillness of a landscape; the subject alone does not determine how busy the image must become.

Object source · Open artwork

06 / 20

The Girl with a Doll

Henri Rousseau

c.1904 - 1905 · Oil on canvas · Musée de l'Orangerie



Henri Rousseau. The girl with a doll. WikiArt source label: Public domain. Proportional resize and JPEG compression; no crop. Source: https://www.wikiart.org/en/henri-rousseau/the-girl-with-a-doll-1905 · Public domain (WikiArt source label)

The doll repeats the presence of a small figure within the child's frontal pose. Her enlarged head and red dress give her more visual weight than the narrow ground or open sky behind. Rather than presenting a fleeting gesture of play, Rousseau makes child and object stand together in a sustained, direct arrangement.

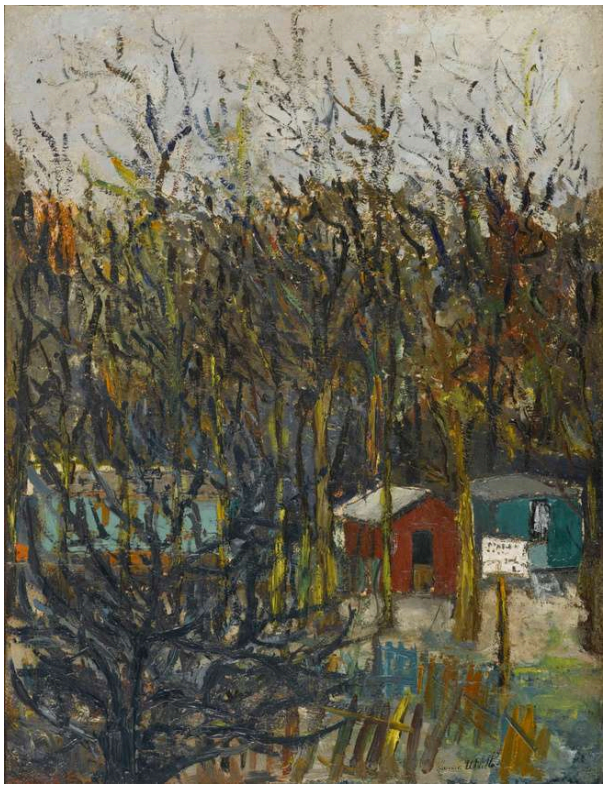
Object source · Open artwork

07 / 20

Butte Pinson

Maurice Utrillo

1905–1908 · Musée de l’Orangerie



Maurice Utrillo. Butte Pinson. Image credit: Maurice Utrillo. Wikimedia Commons. Public domain (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/mark/1.0/). Resized and JPEG-compressed; selected source frame preserved. · Public domain

Leafless branches intervene between the viewer and the small building. Their dark mesh prevents the house from becoming a simple destination for the eye, while pale water and sky remain visible through the gaps. The view is structured by obstruction: what stands in the way is as consequential as what lies beyond.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: RF 1963 104

08 / 20

Odalisque in Red Trousers

Henri Matisse

1924–1925 · Musée de l’Orangerie



Henri Matisse. Odalisque in red trousers. Image credit: JackyM59. Wikimedia Commons. Public domain (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/mark/1.0/). Resized and JPEG-compressed; selected source frame preserved. · Public domain

The reclining body occupies a room whose textiles make a competing claim on attention. The pale blouse offers a quieter area among the patterns, but does not free the figure from them. Depth is repeatedly checked by decoration, allowing the interior to read both as a place containing a person and as adjoining fields of colour.

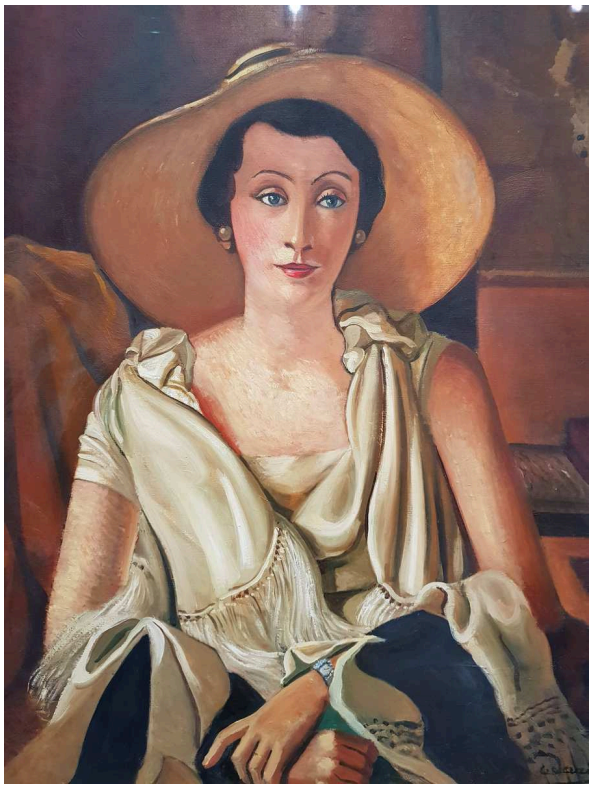
Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: RF 1963 66

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Madame Guillaume in a Wide-Brimmed Hat

André Derain

1928–1929 · Musée de l’Orangerie



André Derain. Portrait of Madame Guillaume with pamela. Image credit: Philippe Cendron. Wikimedia Commons. Public domain (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/mark/1.0/). Resized and JPEG-compressed; selected source frame preserved. · Public domain

The broad hat gives the portrait a circular upper boundary, answered by the gloves and fabric gathered below. Within this stable arrangement, the face remains particular. Fashionable dress supplies weight and structure rather than mere ornament, making the sitter's public presentation inseparable from the clothes through which she appears.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: RF 1960-36

10 / 20

Water Lilies: Sunset

Claude Monet

1914–1926 · Musée de l’Orangerie



Claude Monet. The Water Lilies - Setting Sun. Image credit: Claude Monet. Wikimedia Commons. Public domain (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/mark/1.0/). Resized and JPEG-compressed; selected source frame preserved. · Public domain

Warm reflections extend across six metres of painted pond. That width matters: the image cannot be grasped in the same bodily relation as a small framed portrait. Water provides a surface on which sky and aquatic growth coexist, and the absence of a conventional foreground makes colour changes do much of the work of orientation.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: INV 20103

11 / 20

The Road from Montbuisson to Louveciennes

Alfred Sisley

1875 · Musée de l'Orangerie



Alfred Sisley. The Road from Montbuisson to Louveciennes. Image credit: Miguel Hermoso Cuesta. Wikimedia Commons. CC BY-SA 3.0 (https://creativecommons.org/licenses/by-sa/3.0). Resized and JPEG-compressed; selected source frame preserved. · CC BY-SA 3.0

The pale road gives open fields a direction without filling them. Small walkers measure its recession, while the extensive sky prevents that route from occupying all the picture's attention. Sisley makes an ordinary passage through land legible through proportion: a modest human use persists within a setting considerably larger than itself.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: RF 1960-47

12 / 20

Water Lilies: Clear Morning with Willows

Claude Monet

1914–1926 · Musée de l’Orangerie



Claude Monet. The Water Lilies - Clear Morning with Willows. Image credit: Claude Monet. Wikimedia Commons. Public domain (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/mark/1.0/). Resized and JPEG-compressed; selected source frame preserved. · Public domain

Hanging willow branches repeat across the wide surface, crossing pale water and their own reflections. Their downward movement provides an organising rhythm where a conventional horizon might be expected. Distinguishing solid tree from reflected tree takes time, because both inhabit a painted field that repeatedly brings them together.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: INV 20106

13 / 20

Water Lilies: Green Reflections

Claude Monet

1914–1926 · Musée de l’Orangerie



Claude Monet. The Water Lilies - Green Reflections. Image credit: Claude Monet. Wikimedia Commons. Public domain (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/mark/1.0/). Resized and JPEG-compressed; selected source frame preserved. · Public domain

Clusters of lily pads and lighter intervals have to establish distance without a visible bank or clear horizon. The water is not an empty area between objects; it is the continuous field within which every distinction must be made. Moving across the painting becomes a matter of comparing densities rather than following one receding path.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: INV 20102

14 / 20

Altar Boy

Chaim Soutine

1927 - 1928 · Musée de l’Orangerie



Chaim Soutine. Altar Boy. WikiArt source label: Public domain. Proportional resize and JPEG compression; no crop. Source: https://www.wikiart.org/en/chaim-soutine/altar-boy-1928 · Public domain (WikiArt source label)

The red and white vestments identify a formal role, but the fabric and body do not settle into perfect symmetry. Joined hands concentrate the pose while the twisting white area keeps it uneasy. The portrait preserves the difference between an individual's physical presence and the stable public identity that a costume can promise.

Object source · Open artwork

15 / 20

Antonia

Amedeo Modigliani

Date unverified: 1915 · Musée de l’Orangerie



Amedeo Modigliani. Antonia. Image: WikiArt. Public domain (WikiArt label). Proportionally resized and JPEG compressed; no crop. · Public domain (WikiArt label)

The black dress provides a restrained base for the long neck and pale face. Small tilts of head and shoulders interrupt the apparent balance of the seated, forward-facing pose. Modigliani makes those departures consequential by leaving the surrounding interior shallow: there is little elsewhere in the picture to divert attention from them.

Object source · Open artwork

16 / 20

Deer

Marie Laurencin

1923 · Musée de l’Orangerie



Marie Laurencin. Deer. Image: WikiArt. Public domain (WikiArt label). Proportionally resized and JPEG compressed; no crop. · Public domain (WikiArt label)

Animals and human figures share a soft blue-grey range, broken by pink and white. Their curved, overlapping outlines make recognition emerge from neighbouring forms rather than from hard separations. The bodies remain available to identify, but the image also keeps their shared colour relationships visible as a subject of attention.

Object source · Open artwork

17 / 20

Landscape with Figures

Chaim Soutine

1918 - 1919 · Musée de l'Orangerie



Chaim Soutine. Landscape with Figures. WikiArt source label: Public domain. Proportional resize and JPEG compression; no crop. Source: https://www.wikiart.org/en/chaim-soutine/landscape-with-figures-1919 · Public domain (WikiArt source label)

The road, houses and trees all take part in the view's tilting movement. A small figure supplies a familiar scale but cannot stabilise the whole landscape. Soutine extends distortion beyond one object, making it a condition of the surrounding space rather than an isolated oddity that could be corrected independently.

Object source · Open artwork

18 / 20

Yvonne and Christine Lerolle at the Piano

Pierre-Auguste Renoir

c. 1897 · Musée de l’Orangerie



Pierre-Auguste Renoir. Yvonne et Christine Lerolle au piano. WikiArt: Public domain. Proportional resize and JPEG compression; no crop. · Public domain (WikiArt per-object label)

One sister plays while the other follows the music nearby, their heads and shoulders drawn into a shared area of attention. The dark piano holds their white and red clothing together without making the poses identical. The activity is cooperative through different actions, not through two figures performing exactly the same movement.

Object source · Open artwork

19 / 20

Claude Renoir as a Clown

Pierre-Auguste Renoir

1909 · Musée de l’Orangerie



Pierre-Auguste Renoir. Claude Renoir en clown. WikiArt: Public domain. Proportional resize and JPEG compression; no crop. · Public domain (WikiArt per-object label)

The red costume enlarges the child's outline, while the small shoes and straight legs keep its wearer physically legible beneath the theatrical shape. His serious face does not simply echo the costume's promise of entertainment. That distinction allows a named child and a performed role to remain visible at the same time.

Object source · Open artwork

20 / 20

Nude Woman in a Landscape

Pierre-Auguste Renoir

1883 · Musée de l’Orangerie



Pierre-Auguste Renoir. Femme nue dans un paysage. WikiArt: Public domain. Proportional resize and JPEG compression; no crop. · Public domain (WikiArt per-object label)

The body's seated weight remains clear even where its boundary softens into foliage. Warm skin and cooler vegetation meet through related rounded forms rather than an equally sharp contour everywhere. The backward turn introduces an outward connection while leaving the figure integrated into the landscape's broader colour arrangement.

Object source · Open artwork

Read the dimensions as well as the image

A screen can give Monet's long panels and a compact portrait the same apparent width. Keep their recorded sizes in mind when comparing them in Artline. Before visiting, consult the museum for current arrangements; this selected list is not a complete account of its displays.

Further reading

Impressionism: A Centenary Exhibition

Anne Dayez, Michel Hoog and Charles S. Moffett · Read online or download · English

The Met's Impressionism: A Centenary Exhibition provides background for Monet, Renoir and Sisley. It concerns their earlier period, so it is a starting point rather than an account of every twentieth-century work here.

Museum website · Official collection guide

Sources and visitor information checked: 2026-10-12

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